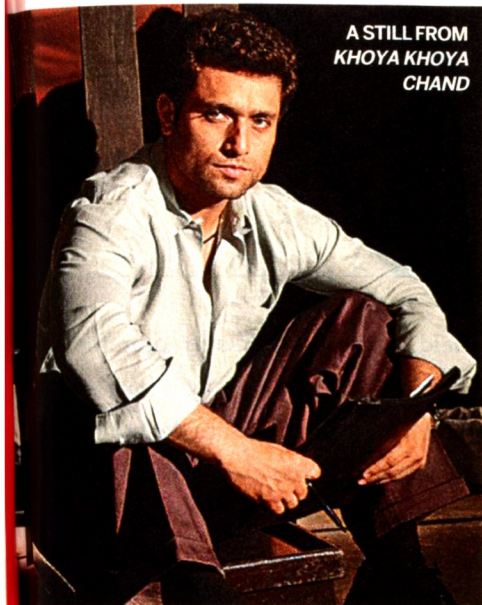




A STILL FROM
*KHOYA KHOYA
CHAND*

ground—from the Army Public School to Hansraj College—will be dividing his time between the police station lock-up and court. It is also clear that Bollywood, which rallies around its own, whether it is Sanjay Dutt or even director Madhu Bhandarkar who was charged with raping a starlet, has chosen to look the other way here. Mohit Suri, director of Ahuja's *Woh Lamhe*, puts it clearly: "Rape has nothing to do with sex; it has everything to do with power." Sleeping with starlets, turning up drunk on sets, shooting black bucks and even running over people, Bollywood tends to dismiss the misconduct of successful people as aberrations.

Ahuja, unfortunately, was not quite the star he had hoped to become when he first burst on the scene with Sudhir Mishra's *Hazaaron Khwaishen Aisi* in 2005, where he played a smooth-talking huckster in a hurry to succeed. In the past five years, he has acted in 14 movies but his biggest hit has been Anurag Basu's *Gangster*, where he played a lovestruck mobster. Those who

worked with him closely at that time remember him saying he would be bigger than Amitabh Bachchan.

That confidence turned out to be misplaced, with three star vehicles, Tanuja Chandra's *Zindaggi Rocks*, Mishra's *Khoya Khoya Chand*, and Kunal Shivdasani's *Hijack*, failing spectacularly. "I remember telling him that he was destroying his career by believing in the lies he was being fed," says filmmaker Mahesh Bhatt. That was the time when Ahuja was starting to taste the power of money, demanding and getting Rs 1.5 crore to Rs 2 crore for a film. "But he had realised the error of his ways, that one should only ask for a price that one can return," says Bhatt. "Shiney wanted to put his career back on

in with him into a bigger house." Ahuja, who started his career in Mumbai as a model, doing almost 60 advertisements, was always obsessed about media coverage, obsessing over column inches and even placement of photographs in city supplements. He has changed at least five publicists in his five-year career, never satisfied with the level of exposure. He has given controversial statements about co-stars and often disparaged them in private conversations. He is not, as Suri puts it politely, "a people's person. He just doesn't have those skills."

And Bollywood is a lot about relationships. Those matter when character certificates are required, as in the case of actor and presenter Aman Verma, who was accused of proposi-



“ This act, if true, defies logic. I just cannot reconcile it with the abiding image of the good-looking boy who worked with me in 2000. ”

SUDHIR MISHRA, DIRECTOR, *HAZAARON KHWAISHEN AISI*

track. Sadly it didn't happen." Basu, who directed him in *Gangster* and *Life...in a Metro*, says he had a conversation with him recently when he confessed that he didn't have any films on hand. His imminent release, Jahnu Barua's *Har Pall*, has been ready for over a year, and he had turned down critical favourites such as *Oye Lucky! Lucky Oye!* because of money issues.

Mishra, who has produced or directed three films with him, *Hazaaron...*, Ruchi Narain's *Kal—Yesterday and Tomorrow* and *Khoya Khoya Chand*, says he cannot imagine that "this boy could have raped anyone. I have a lot of women working with me, spitfires all, and they would have kicked him in the b... if he had tried to disrespect them. His wife and he even met me a month ago and he told me he wanted his parents to move

tioning a journalist in a sting operation, when Salman Khan and Govinda stepped up to speak for him. Those matter when careers have to be rebuilt, as Salman Khan and Sanjay Dutt have done after every stint in jail. But Ahuja, says his *Sins* director Vinod Pande, who cast him as himself in a cameo in his new movie, *Chaloo Movie*, could never be accused of being humble. "On the sets of *Sins*, I had to discipline him several times for his attitude," he adds.

Ironically, for someone who was constantly looking out for a front page plug or a front row seat at a film function, Ahuja achieved for himself the greatest level of celebritydom wearing what looked like a tablecloth on his face in a police van. As Oscar Wilde, who knew a thing or two about public humiliation, once wrote in *An Ideal Husband*, scandals used to lend charm, or at least interest, to a man—now they crush him. So much that it's unlikely even reality TV, the sterile homeground of deadbeat stars seeking mass redemption, will offer him a second chance. ■



“ He was never a people's person. He doesn't know what to say when. But I've never seen him misbehaving with a woman on sets. ”

MOHIT SURI, DIRECTOR, *WOH LAMHE*